

KILLING THE MESSENGER: REPRESENTATIONALISM AND THE PAINFULNESS OF PAIN

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According to strong representationalism it is in virtue of having a particular representational content that an experience has the specific phenomenal character that it has. This paper argues that representationalism does not have the resources to explain the most salient aspect of the phenomenal character of pain – it is bound to leave out the painfulness of pain or its negative affect. Its central argument proceeds by analysing the rationalising role of pains. According to it, representationalism is committed to a false picture on which a subject who knowingly acts so as to get rid of her pain without thereby getting rid of the bodily condition it represents always behaves irrationally – in so acting she is shooting the messenger. Thus, there can be no viable representationalist account of the phenomenal character of pain.

I

Strong representationalism is perhaps the most prevalent answer to the question in virtue of what do experiences have their particular phenomenal characters. The representationalist answer is that it is in virtue of having a particular representational content that an experience has the specific phenomenal character that it has.¹ For many philosophers the allure of representationalism lies in its promise to naturalise phenomenal

¹ Proponents of representationalism include: A. Byrne, 'Intentionalism Defended', *Philosophical Review*, 110 (2001), pp. 199–239; A. Clark, *A Theory of Sentience* (Oxford UP, 2000); T. Crane, *Elements of Mind* (Oxford UP 2001); F. Dretske, *Naturalizing the Mind* (MIT Press: Bradford Books, 1995); G. Harman, 'The Intrinsic Quality of Experience', in J.E. Toomer (ed.), *Action Theory and Philosophy of Mind* (Philosophical Perspectives, Vol. 4, 1990), pp. 31–52; W.G. Lycan, *Consciousness and Experience* (MIT Press: Bradford Books, 1996); M. Tye, *Ten Problems of Consciousness* (MIT Press: Bradford Books, 1996); M. Tye, *Consciousness, Color, and Content* (MIT Press, 2000); and M. Tye, 'Representationalism and the Transparency of Experience', *Noûs*, 36 (2002), pp. 137–51. A weaker thesis associated with representationalism is that phenomenal characters merely supervene on the representational contents of experiences (see below).

consciousness: combine representationalism with a naturalistic psychosemantics on which experiences have their content in virtue of possessing some natural property, such as the tracking theory of intentionality, and voilà – you have thereby naturalised phenomenality. Reductive representationalist accounts typically take the contents of experiences to be Russellian contents which involve complexes of properties in the world; and the relevant properties are standardly taken to be response-independent physical properties, such as bodily disturbances, reflectance properties and chemical properties.² Thus, one to one correspondence between phenomenal characters and ways the mind-independent world might be prevails. Relatedly, representationalism of this variety is usually taken by its proponents to solve the explanatory gap problem by, as Shoemaker puts it, ‘kicking the phenomenal character downstairs, into the external world’.³ To the question why an experience that represents e.g., redness has the phenomenal character that it has, it triumphantly answers that the quality that one is directly aware of upon having this experience is redness. How else should redness feel? This, indeed, is an attractive picture.

Consider the parallel answer to the question why, say, your experience of a pain in your forearm has the phenomenal character that it has.⁴ The simplest representationalist answer appears to be roughly the following:

² Philosophers who explicitly endorse that package of views include: Dretske, *Naturalizing the Mind*; Lycan, *Consciousness and Experience*; Tye, *Ten Problems of Consciousness*; Tye, *Consciousness, Color, and Content*; and Tye, ‘Representationalism and the Transparency of Experience’.

³ See S. Shoemaker, ‘Content, Color, and Character’, *Philosophical Issues*, 13 (2003), pp. 253–78, at p. 256.

⁴ Most representationalists endorse ‘unrestricted representationalism’ (Byrne’s term, see his ‘Intentionalism Defended’), on which the thesis applies to all sensory experiences, including bodily sensations such as pains. There are well known difficulties with ‘restricted representationalism’. See, for example, Byrne, *ibid.*; A. Kind, ‘Restrictions on Representationalism’, *Philosophical Studies*, 134 (2007), pp. 405–27. For defenders of pain representationalism, see, for example, D.T. Bain, ‘Intentionalism and pain’, *Philosophical Quarterly*, 53 (2003), pp. 502–23; Byrne, *ibid.*; B. Cutter, and M. Tye, ‘Tracking Representationalism and the Painfulness of Pain’, *Philosophical Issues*, 21 (2011), pp. 90–109; Dretske, *Naturalizing the Mind*; F. Dretske, ‘How Do You Know You Are Not A Zombie?’, in B. Gertler (ed.), *Privileged Access: Philosophical Accounts of Self-Knowledge* (Hampshire, UK: Ashgate Publishing, 2003); Harman, ‘The Intrinsic Quality of Experience’; W. Seager, ‘Emotional Introspection’, *Consciousness and Cognition*, 11 (2002), pp. 666–87; Tye, *Ten Problems of Consciousness*; M. Tye, ‘A Representational Theory of Pains and their Phenomenal Character’, in N. Block, O. Flanagan and G. Güzelçere (eds), *The Nature of Consciousness: Philosophical Debates* (MIT Press, 1997); M. Tye, ‘Another Look at Representationalism about Pain’, and ‘In Defence of Representationalism: Replies to Commentators’, in M. Aydede (ed.), *Pain: New Essays on its Nature and the Methodology of its Study* (MIT Press, 2006). For critiques see, for example, M. Aydede, ‘Naturalism, Introspection and Direct Realism about Pain’, *Consciousness & Emotion*, 2 (2001), pp. 29–73; M. Aydede, ‘The Main Difficulty with Pain: Commentary on Tye’ in Aydede, *Pain: New Essays on its Nature and the Methodology of its Study*; N. Block, ‘Bodily Sensations as an Obstacle for Representationalism’, in Aydede, *ibid.*; B. Maund, in Aydede, *ibid.*; and P. Noordhof, in Aydede, *ibid.*

the property that you are directly aware of upon having that experience – the property that your experience represents – is a particular bodily disturbance in a certain location in your forearm.⁵ However, as opponents of representationalism have noted, and as proponents of representationalism now acknowledge, this answer will not do. For it fails to explain what is perhaps the most interesting and salient aspect of the phenomenology of pain – its painfulness or negative affect.⁶ Thus, Cutter and Tye (*Tracking Representationalism*, p. 92) say:

... [I]f tissue damage is all that pain experience represents, then it's hard to explain one salient aspect of its phenomenal character, namely its negative affect. Pains don't merely inform us of the presence of some disturbance at a location in our bodies; they hurt. A theory which says that pain experiences merely represent tissue damage at some location in one's body would seem to leave out the painfulness of pain.

That is, if the content of pain is exhausted by information concerning the location and physiological type of a bodily disturbance, then the phenomenal character of pain – specifically, its painfulness aspect – cannot be explained by its content.

The representationalist may fall back on the much weaker position that the phenomenal character of pain is not explained by, but rather merely supervenes on, its representational content. But, again, as is acknowledged by proponents of representationalism, there are strong reasons against this move (Cutter and Tye, *ibid.*, p. 95):

[T]he tracking representationalist ought not respond to the above argument by citing such an explanatory gap... We do not think that there is any very interesting explanatory gap having to do with an inability to understand or explain why, given that a state has such-and-such representational properties, it has this phenomenal character rather than some other phenomenal character...

⁵ In 'Intentionalism and pain', Bain distinguishes between 'micro injury' versions of pain representationalism, on which the represented physiological property is some micro-physiological condition, such as firing 'nociceptors', and 'macro injury' versions, on which that property is some macro-level property such as 'disorder', where a body part's being disordered is a matter of its being in a pathological condition—its having something wrong with it. In what follows I will focus on (the more prevalent) macro injury versions; however, the argument to be presented below purports to show that painfulness cannot be explained solely by an appeal to the physiological properties represented by pains *whatever those properties are* and so it targets also micro injury versions. It is worth noting that Bain, unlike most pain representationalists, holds that the contents of pains are Fregean rather than Russellian.

⁶ For forceful criticisms of representationalist treatments of pains' affect see, for example, Aydede, 'Naturalism, Introspection and Direct Realism about Pain', and 'The Main Difficulty with Pain: Commentary on Tye'.

Moreover, if the tracking representationalist concedes that the content of pain experience cannot explain this aspect of its phenomenal character, this undermines our reason to accept that the latter supervenes on the former. Lacking an explanation of why, given that a pain experience represents the presence of a bodily disturbance, it must have the phenomenal property of being painful, we have at least some reason to think that it is possible for an experience to have the former (representational) property without having the latter (phenomenal) property. It seems possible, after all, that a purely tactile experience could represent that there is some physiological disturbance at a certain location in our bodies without that experience having the negative affect involved in typical pain experiences.

Finally, another route better not taken by representationalists is that of trying to explain the negative aspect of the phenomenology of pain by appealing to the subject's desires to rid herself of pain.⁷ This route, as many have stressed, appears to put the cart before the horse: 'When people desire (and try) to rid themselves of pain, it is because the pain feels bad.'⁸ (*ibid.*, p. 7)

The obvious move for the representationalists, then, is to deny that the content of pain is exhausted by information concerning the location and physiological type of a bodily disturbance, information which concerns valuation-neutral properties. If they are to have any prospect of accounting for the negative phenomenal quality of hurtfulness, the relevant contents must be taken to be *richer*, in that they not only represent the presence of a bodily disturbance but also represent that disturbance as having some *negative valuational property*. Indeed, this is the route representationalists have recently taken, in proposing that pain experiences represent bodily disturbances as, e.g., *noxious or bad* for the subject (properties which, they argue in detail, can be naturalised and shown to be causally efficacious in the way that is required by the tracking theory).⁹ Simply put, the experience of pain feels bad because what it represents – the (mind-independent) property the subject is directly aware of upon having

⁷ See, though, A. Clark, 'Painfulness is not a Quale', in Aydede, *Pain: New Essays on its Nature and the Methodology of its Study*. Clark argues that pain's negative affect consists of functional connections of pain experiences to drive states.

⁸ As Cutter and Tye admit in the context of addressing Pautz' forceful objection that the simple representationalist view cannot account for the difference in degree of painfulness of the pain experiences of two possible subjects – Mild and Severe – whose pain experiences do not differ with respect to what bodily disturbance (d) they represent (*ibid.*, p. 6): 'Of course there will be a difference in the strength of their desires to rid themselves of (d), but this difference should be explained by the difference in how bad their pains feel. Severe desires to rid himself of (d) much more strongly than Mild does because Severe's pain feels much worse than Mild's pain does'. For Pautz' objection, see his 'A Simple View of Consciousness', in R. Koons and G. Bealer (eds), *The Waning of Materialism* (Oxford UP, 2010).

⁹ For a detailed defence on the idea that such properties can be appropriately naturalised see Cutter and Tye, 'Tracking Representationalism and the Painfulness of Pain'.

this experience – is (represented as) bad. Thus, the subject's desire to rid herself of pain is explained, exactly as it should, by the phenomenology of pain – pains tend to elicit such desires, and to rationalise them, because they feel bad; and their feeling bad is exhaustively explained – exactly as the phenomenal character of redness is explained – by the (mind-independent) property they represent.

In the next section I shall further elucidate the commitments of a representationalist account of the negative phenomenal quality of the experience of pain. I shall then argue that any attempt to explain that quality solely by enriching the content of pain is doomed to fail. Thus, representationalism cannot explain the hurtfulness of pain.

II

Let us call mental states which involve evaluative dimensions – e.g., desires, which possess such a dimension at least in part due to their psychological modes, and evaluative beliefs, which possess such a dimension due to their rich evaluative contents – ‘con attitudes’ or ‘pro attitudes’ (as the case may be). Con-attitudes such as desires and preferences are conative con-attitudes; con-attitudes such as evaluative beliefs, as well as those that, according to the representationalist, are involved in pain-experiences, are cognitive con-attitudes. I suggest that a natural starting point for an analysis of the hurtfulness of pain is the following question. It is almost obvious that con-attitudes or negative evaluations of some sorts are (at least typically) associated with pains. But what are the objects of these attitudes? What is it that one who is in pain evaluates as bad? Two possible replies readily suggest themselves:

1. The evaluations associated with pains are of the intentional objects of the pains – they evaluate negatively the bodily disturbances that pains represent.
2. The evaluations associated with pains are of the pains themselves, or, specifically, of the unpleasant phenomenal quality of painfulness.

The representationalist may voice a twofold complaint at this point. First, on her view, pains ordinarily involve two con-attitudes rather than one. They involve a cognitive con-attitude that is directed towards the bodily condition they represent – they represent that bodily disturbance as, e.g., bad; and they also involve a second con-attitude, a higher-order one, which, in a sense to be immediately explained, is directed towards themselves. The latter con-attitude is a conative con-attitude – namely, the

familiar desire to get rid of the pain, and it is explained by the presence of the former cognitive con-attitude, namely, the one whose (negative) valence is rooted in what it represents. Secondly, since the phenomenal aspect of painfulness consists in representing the bodily disturbance as, e.g., bad or noxious, the higher-order attitude is directed *both* towards that noxious bodily disturbance and towards the phenomenal character of pain – these are actually one and the same feature. The phenomenal character of pain, which consists in its representational content, involves qualities of the sort that qualify bodily disturbances, just as redness, which enters into the content of some visual experiences, qualifies surfaces of external objects.

Bearing this clarification in mind, and agreeing that positive answers to (1) and (2) need not be mutually exclusive, let us raise an initial consideration in favour of the idea that the desire (i.e., the second-order attitude) is directed (at least also) towards the represented bodily disturbance. Consider what representationalists refer to as the ‘transparency of experiences’. They argue that when we, say, look at a red object, redness is *experienced as a feature of this object*. Moreover, when we attempt to direct our attention ‘inward’ – to the experience of redness and its (alleged) ‘intrinsic’ features, we find that there is nothing there to attend to – we are still attending to the redness of the object ‘out there’.¹⁰ Some representationalists explicitly apply this idea to pain.¹¹ On their view, when one tries to turn one’s attention inward, to the intrinsic features of the experience of pain one feels in one’s hand, one does not seem to come across anything apart from what this experience represents. The only features there to attend to are features one experiences *in one’s hand*. Now a corollary of this view is that *one’s dislike*, or *the aversion which assails one whenever one is in pain*, is also (introspectively) apprehended as directed at these (represented) features: one seems to wish *the condition of one’s hand* to change.¹² If appearances are telling in this case, then standardly it is (at least also) this condition that one wishes to change. Furthermore, it might be argued, one wishes to get rid of one’s pain only in so far as it is this condition that the pain represents.

¹⁰ See, for example, Harman, ‘The Intrinsic Quality of Experience’; and Tye, ‘Representationalism and the Transparency of Experience’.

¹¹ See, for example, Tye, *ibid.*; and T. Crane, ‘The Intentional Structure of Consciousness’, in ? Smith and ? Jolic (eds), *Consciousness: New Philosophical Perspectives* (Oxford UP, 2003).

¹² See, for example, Tye, *ibid.*, at pp. 8–9.

III

Let us dwell a little further on the nature of the con-attitudes that are directed towards the experiences of pains, by focusing on the ways those attitudes are rationalised by pains. We may begin by appealing to cases of non-veridical pains, and specifically, to the *reason-giving force* of such pains. Consider, for example, the various clinical conditions in which even the mildest, most innocuous, touch can cause an excruciating pain. Or consider phantom pains – unrelenting pains which are experienced as occurring in organs which the subjects do not have. The pains of those tormented subjects suffering from either of these conditions falsely represent that certain bad or noxious bodily disturbances obtain, and the subjects are typically aware that no such disturbances obtain. Yet even in these cases it seems that the subjects' pains do provide them with reasons for action. These subjects certainly do not strike us as irrational in reacting to their pains in particular ways – their attempts to change their condition *are* reasonable. It may seem that a subject who undergoes a non-veridical pain and is aware of this fact is lacking one reason for action that a subject whose pain is veridical has. But it certainly seems that she does have some (other) reason for action which is rooted in her pain – a reason that she and the subject whose pain is veridical share. This much appears to be a piece of data which should constrain any analysis of pain.

Now the reason associated with, e.g., a phantom pain is not a reason to get rid of, or change, the noxious bodily condition it represents. For in such cases, no such condition obtains, and we may assume that the subject – who, as emphasised above, behaves rationally – is aware that no such condition obtains. Yet this reason is a reason to act so as to get rid of the pain itself. Thus, if we move from this reason to the con-attitude which expresses it, the condition which this attitude prescribes should be changed is the condition of one's being in pain. When a subject has a reason to perform a certain action and is motivated accordingly, the con-attitude which expresses this reason is directed towards the object which the action is supposed to influence; in the cases under considerations, this object is the pain itself.

This idea is quite general and does not hinge on an appeal to non-veridical pains. Indeed, we may just as well illustrate it using the prosaic example of taking a pain killer. Pain killers do not 'kill' the noxious bodily conditions represented by the pains – their function is symptomatic only. Yet, even if one is aware of this limited function, one may certainly have reasons to take pain killers. Thus, one has reasons to get rid of one's

pains, even without getting rid of the noxious bodily conditions they represent. And so, the attitudes which express those reasons also concern the pains themselves. We see, then, two kinds of cases, which lead to the same idea. There are cases (namely, those of non-veridical pains) in which one has a reason to get rid of one's pain in spite of the fact that the represented noxious bodily condition does not obtain; and there are cases (such as those of taking pain-killers) in which one has a reason to get rid of one's pain in spite of the fact that this noxious bodily condition (which does obtain) cannot (or will not, as a result of the action prescribed by this reason) be changed. A subject who attempts to get rid of her pain – even without getting rid of its intentional object – often behaves rationally. Thus, a subject's being in pain gives her a reason to get rid of her pain *even without getting rid of the intentional object of her pain*, and this reason (typically) expresses itself in the subject's having a con-attitude directed against her pain. This conclusion regarding the way pains rationalise the relevant desires is the premise of the argument to which I now turn.

IV

How, then, can the relevant reasons and the con-attitudes which express them be explained? Recall that it was the need to explain the ('external') con-attitudes associated with pains – the ones which best reflect the negative phenomenal character of painfulness – that led the representationalist to postulate that pains involve (first-order) cognitive con-attitudes, i.e., that the contents of pains are rich valuational contents that represent their objects as bad. Are such rich contents indeed capable of explaining the relevant attitudes? Can the thesis that pain experiences involve (first-order) cognitive con-attitude directed towards their intentional object explain the fact that pain rationalises, and is typically accompanied by, a (second-order) con-attitude directed towards itself in the way just explained?

The (first-order) cognitive-evaluative attitudes that are postulated to be constitutive of pain represent the bodily disturbance as bad, damaging, etc.; their having such rich negative valuational contents is what makes them *con*-attitudes. These attitudes might be understood to be belief-like attitudes, or (more plausibly) attitudes whose assertoric force is weaker than that of a belief (attitudes we may call 'seemings'). The question of the exact nature of their psychological modes, though, is not important for the present purpose. For the point I am driving at is that even the reason-giving force of cognitive-evaluative attitudes with the strongest

assertoric force – such as evaluative beliefs – is, in a sense, too weak to account for the reason-giving force of pain and for the existence of the second-order attitude. Hence, I will ignore that question, and occasionally speak of the relevant cognitive evaluation as an evaluative belief.

Let us consider, then, the way in which cognitive con-attitudes such as evaluative beliefs provide reasons, and then compare it with the way in which pains provide reasons.¹³ The reason which an evaluative belief provides is rooted solely in the evaluable or normative features of the object which it represents. That is, it is rooted in normative features the motivated subject (explicitly or implicitly) takes this object to have (or lack) *independently of her pro/con attitudes towards this object* (and, specifically, independently of this very belief). Such a reason is conceived as independent of, and merely reflected by, the motivating state that expresses it. When a subject is motivated to act by an evaluative belief, she takes into account the fact – which presents itself as independent of herself and her motivating state – that the object of the motivating state is evaluable in some objective respect. She *does not* take into account the fact, about herself, that she *believes* that this object is evaluable. In this sense we may say that an evaluative belief is transparent. As Stampe puts it, a belief is ‘a conduit’ for the authority of a belief-independent reason-providing fact.¹⁴ It *informs* the subject that something is good or bad; it is not what *makes* that thing good or bad. The reason-giving force of a belief is rooted in the fact about which the belief informs the subject.

Now return to pains. Recall that a subject’s being in pain gives her a reason to get rid of her pain *even without getting rid of the intentional object of her pain*, and this reason (typically) expresses itself in the subject’s having a con-attitude directed against her pain. Can this datum be explained by assuming that painfulness consists in a (first-order) *cognitive*-evaluative attitude regarding the bodily condition represented by the pain? It cannot. As we’ve just seen, a cognitive evaluative attitude merely *informs* us that something is good or bad; it is not what *makes* it good or bad – it is not constitutive of the reason-providing fact it is about. This means that, from the perspective of the subject, the existence of the cognitive evaluative attitude can provide no reasons beyond the reasons which are grounded in what it represents – in the evaluable features the intentional object of the attitude has. But if this is so, then if the first-order con-attitude which

¹³ I elaborate on the way in which cognitive con-attitudes provide reasons in H. Jacobson-Horowitz, ‘Motivational Cognitivism and the Argument from Direction of Fit’, *Philosophical Studies*, 127 (2006), pp. 561–80.

¹⁴ See, D. Stampe, ‘The Authority of Desires’, *The Philosophical Review* 96 (1987), pp. 341–81.

pain involves were an evaluative belief (or a cognitive evaluation of any other kind), the existence of the (second-order) con-attitude directed towards the pain itself would be wholly inexplicable. It would be a mystery why the subject objects – indeed, why it is reasonable for her to object – to the very fact of her being in pain, even if she cannot affect the intentional object of her pain. The postulation of a first-order evaluative belief may certainly explain why the subject has a reason to change *the bodily condition represented by her pain* – this belief informs her that this condition is bad. But it cannot explain why the subject has a reason to change *the condition of her being in pain*, even if she will not thereby get rid of the bodily condition it represents. For one has no reason to object to being in a state which *merely represents* that another state is bad. Since the having of a cognitive con-attitude can only be said to be ‘bad’ in the derivative sense of representing, or informing the subject, that its intentional object is bad, postulating it as constitutive of pain cannot explain the objectionability of the experience of pain – it cannot explain why pain, and not merely its intentional object, is bad.^{15,16}

¹⁵ Some argue that reductive Russellian representationalist accounts of phenomenal character face difficulties in accounting for non-veridical perceptual experiences (see, for example, B. J. Thompson, ‘Representationalism and the Argument from Hallucination’, *Pacific Philosophical Quarterly*, 89, 2008, pp. 384–412). The relevant arguments purport to show that, when ‘empty’ (i.e., having no reference), such contents are metaphysically inadequate for constituting phenomenal characters: if what constitute phenomenal character are the represented properties, then it may seem that in order for an experience to possess a particular phenomenal character, the represented properties must be instantiated. It might be worth noting that the argument presented here against representationalism is quite different. First, as already noted, the problem of accounting for painfulness arises just as well in cases of veridical pains. Secondly, as far as non-veridical pains are concerned, that problem pertains to the *reason-giving force* of mental states with Russellian contents the properties represented by which are not instantiated, rather than to the metaphysical status of such contents. As such, this problem will be left untouched by a convincing representationalist account which shows how such contents can constitute phenomenal characters. To realise that, note that we can bracket the question of whether mental states’ possessing such ‘empty’ Russellian contents metaphysically suffices for their possessing phenomenal characters – a separate question is whether their possessing such contents suffices for their providing (good) reasons for action; non-veridical pains do provide (good) reasons for action, and this fact needs to be explained. Thirdly, note that the present problem does not arise for purely descriptive, valuation-neutral, aspects of the contents of experiences. If a subject is aware that he’s hallucinating a pink elephant, his hallucination would not provide him with good reasons for believing he’s facing a red elephant; similarly, an informed subject viewing a Müller-Lyer drawing would not be justified in believing that the two horizontal lines are of equal length. Yet, non-veridical pain experiences do provide subjects with good reasons for action, a fact which representationalists cannot explain.

¹⁶ I believe this reasoning can be taken one step further to establish that those (first-order) con-attitudes are conative. But this step involves some complications that cannot be adequately addressed in the present paper, and it will have to await another occasion.

Perhaps the following is an instructive way to convey the essence of this idea. If we endorse the suggestion that the first-order con-attitude which is constitutive of pain is cognitive, we are committed to a picture according to which each time we take a pain killer, we behave like the ruler who killed the messenger who brought him bad news. Under this suggestion, our behaviour – as well as the con-attitude which leads to it – is as irrational as the ruler's erratic act of rage. This implausible picture is bluntly inconsistent with the assumption that subjects do have reasons to get rid of their pains even without getting rid of the conditions they represent. Thus, representationalism does not have the resources to explain the most salient aspect of the phenomenal character of the experience of pain – it does leave out the painfulness of pain.

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